

Thé ou Café

Thé ou café

Taking the time to connect over a hot drink.

An interactive story lasting about five minutes, envisioned to be played on an iPad. Inspired by the night patrols conducted in Geneva by social workers' associations, it explores various encounters with people living on the streets through moments of presence and human connection.

The visitor is invited to slow down and listen. The time devoted to each conversation depends on the simple act of pouring a glass of a hot drink: the longer it is filled, the more the story unfolds.

As the seasons go past, relationships evolve and fragments of lives emerge gradually - sometimes quiet, sometimes unexpected. Some connections form instantly; others require patience and repeated visits.

The narrative is conveyed exclusively through voice and is inspired by testimonies gathered during the research phase from social workers and people with lived experience of homelessness.



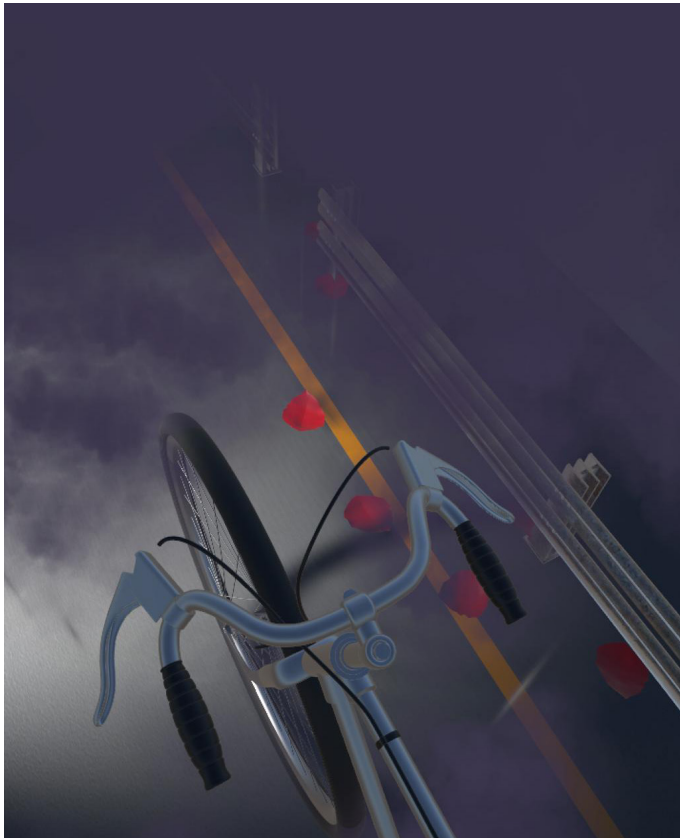
User Journey

The visitor discovers a bicycle moving through the streets in autumn. By pressing and holding the screen, the user slows down and stops the bicycle until they are faced with an empty cup.

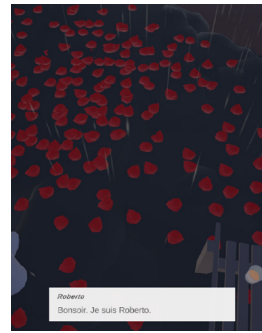
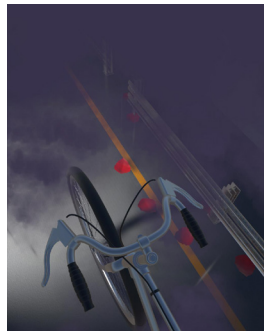
The amount used to fill the cup determines the duration of the exchange: the fuller the cup, the longer the conversation unfolds. The user chooses how much they give. This interaction leads to a meeting with Roberto, who slowly reveals more of his personality.

At the end of each exchange, the user returns to the moving bicycle. This sequence marks the transition to a new season and becomes a recurring ritual between encounters. Season after season, the same cycle repeats: bicycle, stop, give, and meet Roberto. Through these repeated interactions, a relationship develops.

The story ends with one final return to the bicycle in summer. This time, after stopping, Roberto does not appear. His absence remains ambiguous: it is unclear whether he has left, whether he is



autumn



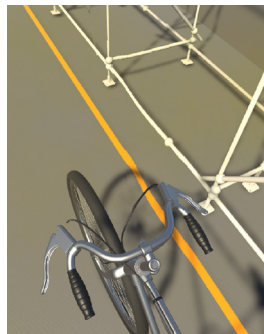
winter



spring



summer



Final Production

The interactive experience is already fully functional as a standalone work, and the current narrative around Roberto is complete. If selected for exhibition, additional production would focus on refining and enriching the existing experience rather than substantially changing it.

1. **Voice recordings:** The current dialogues are inspired by testimonies collected during the research phase. Given more time, we would seek to record the voices of the people who inspired the stories. In particular, we would welcome the opportunity to record the person whose experiences inspired Roberto, should he feel comfortable participating.
2. **Technical polish:** Further production time would allow improvements to the synchronization between dialogue and interaction, smoother scene transitions, and more varied camera movements during bicycle sequences and conversations.
3. **Sound design:** Ambient recordings could be expanded and refined, with the addition of a subtle musical layer to reinforce the atmosphere and rhythm of the narrative.
4. **Exhibition presentation:** Although the experience is designed as an infinite loop, a main title could be added after the autumnal bike scene to provide visitors with a clearer sense of the beginning and end of a narrative cycle within the exhibition context.
5. **Expansion of the narrative:** Building on the research conducted during the project, two additional stories - those of Magla and Fernand, originally conceived for locations under a bridge and in the train station hall - could be integrated into the experience. Following the same interaction mechanics and seasonal progression, these parallel narratives would broaden the portrayal of life on the streets while remaining faithful to the original concept.



Field Research

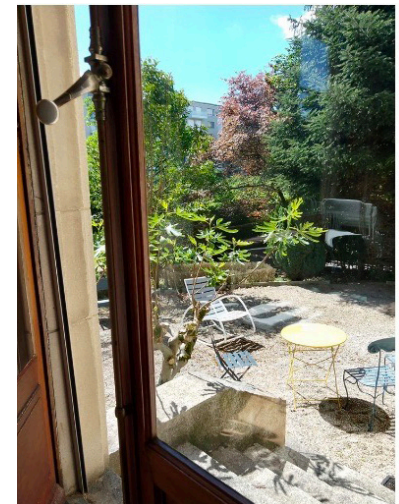
The project started from two open notions: the street and care. What does the street represent to us? What forms of care take place within it? We began by walking through different areas of Geneva, observing the interactions between people and the urban environment, recording small gestures, recurring places, and details found on the ground and on the walls. Gradually, our attention shifted towards life on the streets.

We met Jérôme, co-founder of the Association Maraude, whose bicycle patrols create long-term relationships with people experiencing homelessness through conversation and the simple act of offering tea or coffee. This encounter became the starting point for the interactive experience.

We also attended one of the association's monthly public events, where free crêpes are offered to everyone in the streets, bringing together a diverse public, including many people in situations of precarity.

The research continued through visits to Bateau Genève and Femmes à Bord, spaces that offered the opportunity to observe daily social dynamics and to speak with people experiencing homelessness in a calm and protected environment.

Finally, we met Anaïs, a social worker at the Service social (SOC), Département de la cohésion sociale et de la solidarité, who introduced us to the person whose story inspired the character of Roberto. A regular visitor to Geneva's libraries, his experience became the main narrative thread of the interactive story.



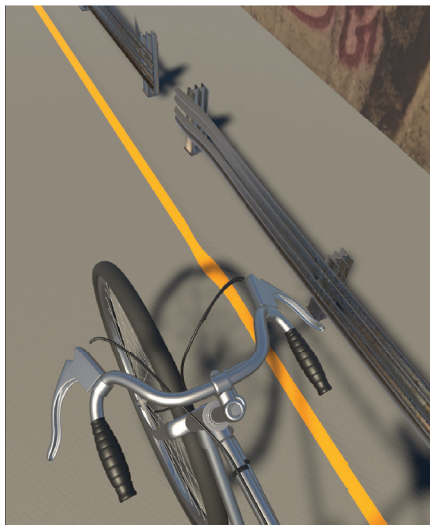
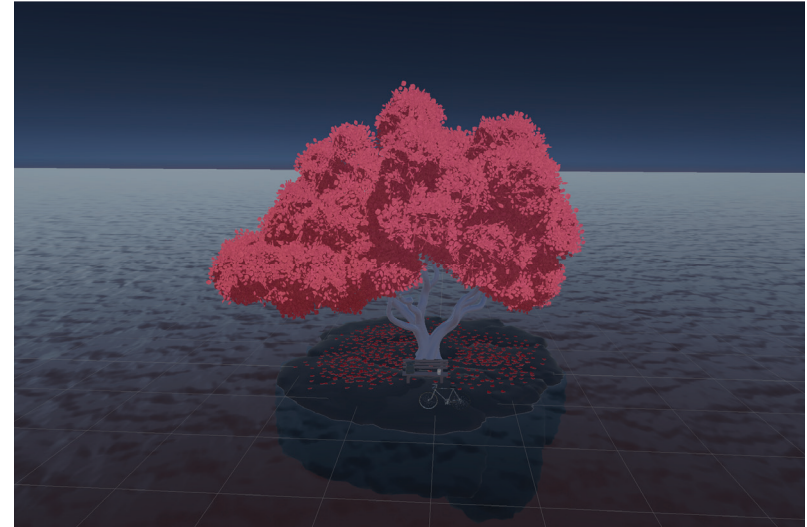
Art Direction

Our art direction is based on a 3D environment with simple shapes, soft colours and clear visual elements. The goal is not to create a realistic world, but a readable and atmospheric scene that supports the story and the interactions.

The scene is built around a small island with a tree, a bench, a bicycle, a cup, water, rain and petals. These objects are familiar and easy to recognise, but they also help create the mood of the project. The composition stays simple so the viewer can quickly understand where to look and what elements are important.

We use the four seasons as a metaphor for time passing. Changes in the tree, colours, light, weather and atmosphere help show different moments and emotional states without needing to change the whole environment. This gives the scene a sense of evolution and progression.

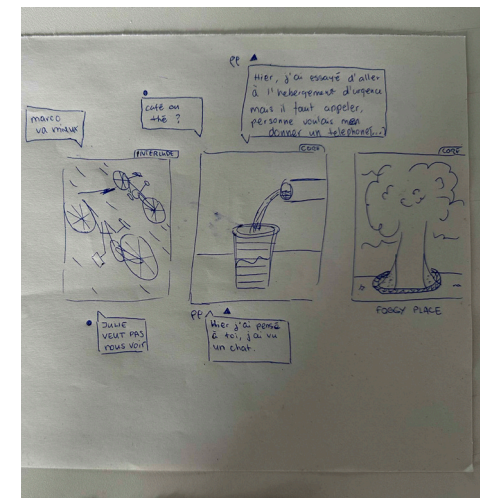
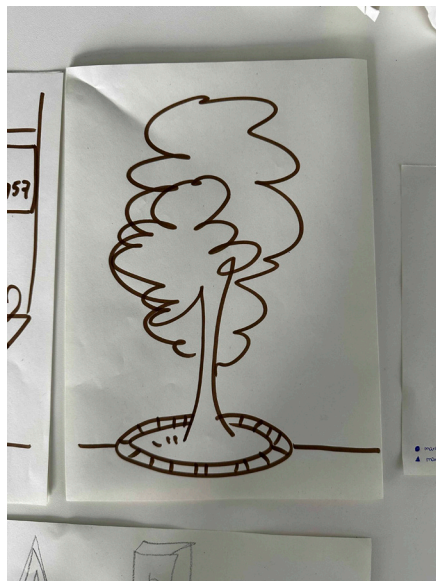
Overall, the art direction is simple and atmospheric. It uses clear objects, seasonal changes and mood shifts to support the narrative and make the world feel coherent.



Cardboard Prototype

From the cardboard testing, we learned how to organize the space before building it in 3D. It helped us understand the scale of the objects, the position of the bike, the tree, the bench, the cup and the city elements. We also tested how the user could move through the scene and where their attention should go.

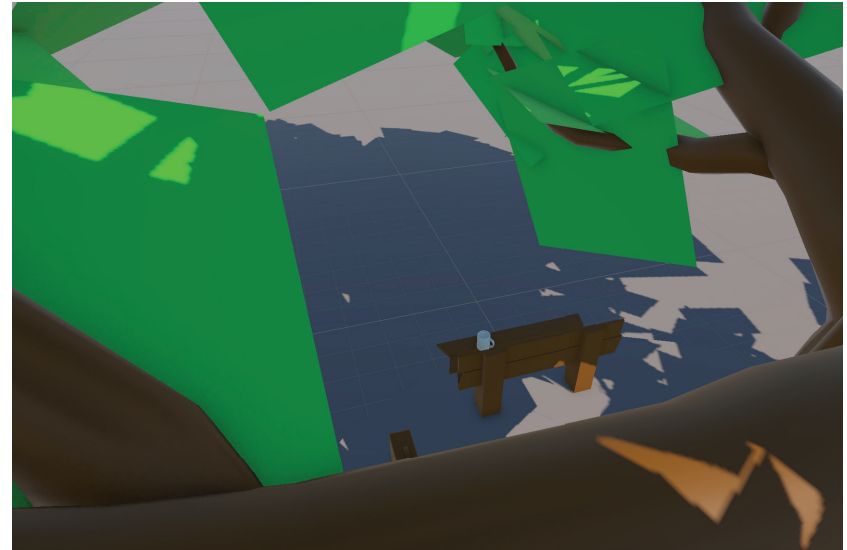
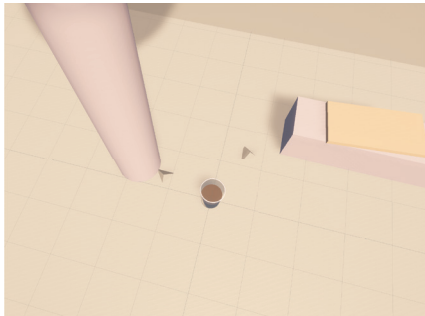
This process showed us that the environment needed to stay simple and clear. Each object had to be easy to recognise and have a purpose in the story. The cardboard prototype helped us decide what to keep, what to simplify, and how to make the interactions more readable.



Greybox Prototype

During the greyboxing phase, we tested the basic structure of the scene before adding final visuals. We focused on the visual composition, the placement of the main elements, and how they worked together in the same space. This helped us check if the tree, bench, cup and other objects were right and if the scene felt coherent.

We also tested camera movement and different points of view. One important test was the cup filling while the camera slowly zooms out, revealing more of the environment. This helped us see if the transition was clear and if the camera movement supported the narrative. The greybox allowed us to quickly adjust the space, scale and framing before moving to more detailed production.



User Tests

We did user tests regularly during the whole process. At different stages, we showed the progress of the project to other groups and people to get feedback and see what was working or not. This helped us understand the project from different points of view and improve the experience step by step.

The user tests were especially useful for the transitions between scenes and for the interactions with the cup and the bike. They helped us understand how the interactions should feel, how much feedback the user needed, and what visual information was necessary to make the actions clear. We made many small adjustments to the touch interactions, because at first some users did not understand that they had to press and hold on the screen.

For the bike scene, the tests helped us improve the braking interaction. Based on feedback, we added the bike bell to show that there was something the user could interact with. We also used a zoom effect to make it clearer that the bike was slowing down or braking.

For the cup scene, we spent a lot of time fine-tuning the long press interaction. The cup fills while the user presses the screen. If the user releases before the first step, around 33%, nothing happens. They can press again and continue filling the cup. Once the cup passes this first step, releasing the press triggers the final transition and the camera starts to zoom out.

We also tested the FPS to check if the experience was running smoothly. This was important because the camera movements, visual effects and interactions needed to feel fluid for the user.

Through the tests, we defined a clearer visual language for the project: a tap creates a zoom-in or zoom-out effect, while a long press creates a longer action and a full zoom. Overall, the user tests helped us make the interactions more understandable, more responsive, and better connected to the narrative.

